



The role of classroom silence in teacher educators' well-being: A case study in TESOL initial teacher education

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ABSTRACT

This study explores the role of classroom silence in the well-being of teacher educators (TEs) within a TESOL ITE program in Türkiye. Data were collected from two experienced TESOL TEs, Ayşe and Bahar, through individual interviews, a paired-depth interview, and weekly voice memos. Although TEs are essential for the professional development of pre-service language teachers (PTs), their well-being, particularly concerning classroom silence, has been largely overlooked in existing research. Applying the Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) model, this study examines how classroom silence impacts TEs' ability to support PTs effectively. Findings revealed that classroom silence arises from three primary sources: curriculum-related issues, PT preparedness, and TE strategies. Curriculum misalignment with PTs' language proficiency and theoretical demands contributes to silence, intensified by PT unpreparedness and cultural backgrounds. In the ITE program, TEs reported emotional tension when managing silence, highlighting the need for adaptive teaching methods (e.g., multimodal materials). The study suggests examining institutional policies to create strategies that alleviate stress and support TEs. Implementing support networks, mentoring programs, and modules can offer emotional and professional resources, reducing isolation and classroom-related stress. Revising the ITE curriculum and providing administrative support can aid TEs in managing demands, enhancing their well-being and engagement with TESOL programs.

1. Introduction

Teacher educators (TEs) play a crucial role in the dynamic field of Teaching English to Speakers of Other Languages (TESOL), serving as essential faculty members of initial teacher education (ITE) programs (Lunenberg et al., 2014) and responsible for developing the professional skills and attitudes of preservice language teachers (PTs). Their influence shapes the future of language education, ensuring that new educators are well-prepared to meet diverse classroom needs. However, despite their pivotal role, the demanding environment of tertiary institutions poses significant threats to the well-being of TEs due to various work-related stressors and challenges (Fetherston et al., 2021; Jayman et al., 2022; Wray & Kinman, 2022).

These workplace challenges can severely undermine the well-being and mental health of academic staff (Shen & Slater, 2021), leading to burnout characterized by emotional and mental exhaustion (Sabagh, 2020), hopelessness (McDermott & Bahr, 2021), diminished personal achievement (Lin et al., 2022), negative self-concept (Rachmawati, 2022), and reduced self-efficacy (Skaalvik & Skaalvik, 2017). Such burnout not only affects TEs' personal health but also impairs their professional capabilities, resulting in

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depersonalization (Yang et al., 2023), negative student interactions (Rafsanjani et al., 2019), and a decreased sense of teaching competence (Sabagh et al., 2018). Additionally, as highlighted by Raksawong et al. (2024), negative teacher characteristics can contribute to students' unwillingness to communicate in L2 classes, further intensifying the challenges TEs face and limiting their ability to foster effective professional learning environments. In the context of TESOL ITE, where positive engagement is essential due to the communicative nature of language education, the well-being of TEs is directly linked to PTs' learning experiences (e.g., Bardach et al., 2022; Brewster et al., 2022).

The literature emphasizes humanizing language TEs by recognizing their unique strengths and struggles (Yuan et al., 2022). This perspective is crucial in addressing the complexities of TEs' experiences, particularly concerning classroom silence, which emerges as a significant but underexamined challenge in TESOL contexts. Classroom silence can disrupt interaction and increase stress for TEs, especially in environments where active communication is essential for professional learning (e.g., King & Harumi, 2020; Ohata, 2005). TEs could respond emotionally to classroom silence with frustration, self-doubt, or anxiety, directly impacting their professional well-being and instructional practices (e.g., Smith & King, 2018).

Moreover, silence is frequently misinterpreted as disengagement when it may instead indicate underlying language anxiety or information-processing challenges (Bao, 2023; Tüm & Kunt, 2013). This misinterpretation underscores the necessity of research to better understand silent cues from pre-service teachers (PTs) and to cultivate a more empathetic teacher education environment. While there is growing research on classroom silence from students' perspectives (Bao, 2023) and from PTs' perspectives in teacher education programs (e.g., Yan & He, 2020), a significant gap remains in the ITE literature regarding silence within content-specific TESOL courses. Specifically, further exploration is needed on how silence is interpreted by TESOL TEs, the emotions associated with it, and its outcomes within the TESOL ITE context. Addressing these gaps acknowledges the complexities of TEs' experiences and contributes to the broader discourse on teacher well-being and the challenges they face in educational settings.

To comprehensively understand how in-class stressors, such as classroom silence, affect TEs' well-being within the TESOL ITE context, this study applies the Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) model (Demerouti et al., 2001). The JD-R model assesses how job demands like heavy workloads and workplace stressors (e.g., classroom silence) can erode resilience (Theron, 2022), while job resources such as social support and constructive feedback enhance emotional well-being and instructional practices (Watson & Tre-gaskis, 2022). TESOL TEs face a range of contextual, personal, and interpersonal challenges that impact their well-being and instructional effectiveness (Coombe, 2020; Yin et al., 2020; Yuan et al., 2022). By examining how TEs' emotional responses to classroom silence influence their teaching, this study aims to provide insights into the need for targeted strategies to support TEs and enhance PT engagement in TESOL ITE programs, thereby offering opportunities to improve language teacher education programs and better prepare future TESOL professionals.

To explore these issues, a qualitative case study was conducted within the TESOL ITE program in Türkiye, involving two experienced TESOL TEs, Ayşe and Bahar, who participated due to their active involvement and willingness to reflect on their experiences. Data collection tools included individual interviews, a paired-depth interview, and weekly voice memos, providing comprehensive insights into how TEs navigated classroom silence and other relevant workplace stressors. The participants offered nuanced reflections on classroom dynamics, job demands, and well-being, which are crucial for understanding the broader context of TESOL teacher education. Applying the JD-R model as the theoretical framework, this study sheds light on how job demands, such as classroom silence, interact with job resources like social support and feedback, affecting TEs' well-being and professional effectiveness. By examining emotional responses and instructional practices as key aspects of professional well-being, this study explores the previously underexamined experiences of TESOL Teacher Educators with classroom silence. Building on this framework, the study explores the following research questions.

RQ1) What are the perceived sources of classroom silence in content-specific courses within initial teacher education from TESOL teacher educators' perspectives?

RQ2) What emotions do TESOL teacher educators associate with classroom silence, and how do these emotions affect their teaching approach and well-being?

RQ3) What are the observed outcomes of classroom silence on classroom dynamics, interaction patterns, and engagement in the TESOL teacher education program?

2. Literature review

2.1. Teacher educator well-being and the impact of pre-service teacher behavior

The teaching workforce encompasses a diverse group of professionals (e.g., teachers, teacher educators) who encounter various pressures that significantly impact their well-being and professional effectiveness. These pressures stem from multiple sources, including workload demands, balancing multiple roles, and managing interpersonal relationships within educational settings. While much of the existing literature focuses on the challenges faced by classroom teachers, it is essential to recognize that TEs also belong to this workforce and experience similar, if not unique, stressors that affect their well-being. In relation, TEs face pressures that affect their well-being and professional effectiveness, including balancing teaching, mentoring, and research (Turner & Garvis, 2023). Additionally, managing classroom dynamics and PT behavior adds further demands, especially for TESOL TEs, who facilitate interaction in language learning environments (UNESCO, 2024). While TESOL-specific challenges are underexplored, research on teachers highlights how student behavior—such as misbehavior, disengagement, and silence—impacts well-being (e.g., Murray et al., 2021). For example, Glock and Kleen (2019) found that student misbehavior significantly contributes to teacher burnout, while Amstad and

Müller (2020) noted that negative student behaviors increase teacher stress, raising the risk of burnout.

Among the challenges faced by TEs, student/PT disengagement—which could particularly be observed as classroom silence—emerges as a significant concern. In TESOL settings, where active participation is essential for effective language acquisition, prolonged silence from PTs could heighten emotional tension for TEs. Research by Ohata (2005) and King and Harumi (2020) highlight that cultural factors and language anxiety are primary contributors to such silence in the classroom. This lack of engagement can understandably lead to frustration and self-doubt among TEs, negatively impacting their emotional well-being and instructional practices. Further supporting this perspective, Skaalvik and Skaalvik (2017) observed that passive student behaviors (e.g., silence) cause teachers to question their teaching effectiveness, thereby intensifying emotional tension. Collectively, these factors illustrate how student disengagement through classroom silence could not only disrupt the learning process but also significantly affect the emotional and professional stability of TEs in TESOL ITE contexts.

The role of TESOL TEs in fostering engagement in content courses adds complexity to their responsibilities in the ITE programs. Actively engaging PTs in in-class discussions aligns with sociocultural theory, highlighting the importance of interaction in professional learning environments (Nguyen, 2019). When classroom silence disrupts this process, it could hinder learning and create professional challenges for TEs, intensifying the emotional tension. Given these challenges, exploring how classroom stressors (i.e., silence) uniquely impact TESOL TEs is essential.

Furthermore, TEs' well-being is intricately linked to their ability to manage classroom dynamics while balancing their professional roles. Given the wide range of responsibilities TEs juggle, including mentoring and supporting the professional development of PTs, Turner et al. (2023) emphasized the need to define TE well-being in more specific terms. Theoretical perspectives on professional well-being underscore the importance of a positive relationship with one's environment for professional fulfillment (e.g., Machell et al., 2015; Ryan & Deci, 2001). Thus, how TEs manage these challenges concerning their surroundings is crucial for their overall well-being.

Given the multifaceted roles TEs play in managing PTs and sustaining their professional identity, PT disengagement through classroom silence presents a significant emotional stressor. For TESOL TEs, cultivating active participation and engagement in professional learning intensifies these challenges. As positive engagement is crucial for TEs' professional satisfaction and effectiveness, the impact of classroom silence on TESOL TEs requires deeper exploration.

2.2. Classroom silence as a challenge in TESOL

Classroom silence in TESOL presents significant challenges, shaped by cultural differences, pedagogical approaches, language anxiety, and student preferences (e.g., King & Harumi, 2020; Tüm & Kunt, 20013). Silence may stem from language barriers, lack of confidence, or cultural norms regarding communication (e.g., Noman & Xu, 2023). For instance, students/PTs may remain quiet due to language anxiety or fear of making mistakes in a TESOL context (Ohata, 2005), while cultural norms may either encourage or inhibit interaction (Nakane, 2007). Additionally, silence can result from student resistance or be a strategic response to content or teaching methods, as some students perceive lesson content as irrelevant or associate English proficiency with social status, thereby influencing their engagement (King & King, 2013). In TESOL settings, where active participation is crucial for effective language acquisition and practice, prolonged silence is reasonably expected to disrupt the dynamics in ITE environments, leading to misunderstandings and affecting PT learning (e.g., Jaworski et al., 2012).

This lack of interaction and communication often causes TEs who expect verbal participation to misinterpret silence as disengagement, resulting in frustration and impatience (e.g., Kिरrane et al., 2017). Consequently, prolonged silence can lead to frustration and self-doubt among TEs, negatively impacting their well-being and teaching practices (Martínez, 2024). Skaalvik and Skaalvik (2017) further support this claim by noting that passive student behaviors like silence cause educators to question their effectiveness, intensifying emotional tension. In TESOL settings, the clash between teacher expectations and student silence frequently leads to emotional dissonance (Golombek, 2015), heightening stress and reducing self-esteem (Nazari & Xodabande, 2023). If not effectively managed, this emotional tension can significantly impact TEs' instructional effectiveness and overall well-being in ITE settings. Therefore, understanding the multifaceted nature of classroom silence is essential for fostering positive TE-PT dynamics and supporting the professional well-being of TEs, as the emotional stress associated with managing silence can lead to burnout and reduced instructional effectiveness (Freeman, 2020).

2.3. The relationship between classroom silence and TE well-being

The interaction between classroom silence, TEs' emotions, and instructional practices significantly affects the teaching and learning environment. When TEs misinterpret silence as disengagement, it can lead to emotional distress and alter their perception of their instructional role and professional identity. For PTs, silence may indicate a natural part of the learning process or contemplation (e.g., Su et al., 2023), but TEs may interpret it as disengagement or resistance, depending on the context (e.g., Smith & King, 2018). This dual nature of silence—either fostering reflection or signaling disengagement—complicates classroom dynamics. The distinction between teacher-controlled silence for reflection and student-initiated silence perceived as disruptive further adds complexity, particularly in TESOL ITE programs where PTs are developing their professional roles.

TEs' emotional responses to classroom silence, in turn, often manifest as frustration, discomfort, or resistance, particularly when they perceive silence as disengagement or misunderstanding (e.g., Bista, 2012). This reaction is tied to emotional labor, the effort TEs invest in managing the emotional complexities of the classroom (e.g., Frenzel et al., 2021). However, fostering emotional resilience and understanding the various meanings of silence—cultural, contemplative, or cognitive—can help TEs reframe these challenges as

opportunities for growth (Benesch, 2017). By recognizing these dynamics, TEs can prevent frustration from escalating into burnout, improving their well-being.

This emotional awareness could support personal resilience and enhance the TESOL ITE experience (e.g., Jennings & Greenberg, 2009). When TEs effectively manage emotional stressors, a supportive classroom climate promoting their well-being and PT engagement could be established. This leads to better educational outcomes in TESOL programs, where teacher emotional health and student participation are closely connected (e.g., Hagenauer & Volet, 2014). Thus, using a structured theoretical framework is crucial to better understand how emotional and instructional challenges interact with external demands (Sulis et al., 2023).

2.4. Applying the Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) model in TESOL teacher education

Understanding the emotional challenges TESOL TEs face is crucial for fostering their well-being. Emotions significantly influence how TEs navigate classroom dynamics, impacting both their professional effectiveness and personal health (e.g., Sulis et al., 2023). To comprehensively examine these challenges, exploring various theoretical perspectives on emotions within TESOL is essential.

From a psychological perspective, emotions are viewed as subjective experiences shaped by internal states (Frenzel et al., 2021). Often categorized as positive or negative, these emotions are pivotal in TEs' reactions to classroom situations. Negative emotions, such as frustration from student silence or disengagement, can lead to emotional exhaustion and burnout (Glaesser et al., 2023). Conversely, positive emotions foster resilience and enhance well-being (Fernandes et al., 2020). However, this perspective may overlook the contextual factors that influence emotional experiences in TESOL Initial Teacher Education (ITE) settings.

On the other hand, the sociocultural perspective offers a more nuanced understanding by emphasizing the role of social interactions and cultural contexts in shaping emotions (Vygotsky, 1978). In TESOL ITE, factors such as cultural norms and language anxiety can influence why PTs remain silent, leading TEs to interpret this silence as disengagement based on underlying cultural dynamics (Nakane, 2007). The ecological systems perspective also broadens this view by considering multiple environmental layers that affect emotions, including institutional policies and community interactions (Bronfenbrenner, 1979; Mercer, 2023; Nguyen, 2019). This perspective underscores the complexity of factors influencing TE well-being beyond individual and immediate social interactions within the given specific context.

While these perspectives provide valuable insights, TESOL ITE settings require a more targeted framework to address the unique combination of factors affecting TEs' emotional responses and instructional practices. The JD-R model (Demerouti et al., 2001) posits that stress and burnout emerge when job demands exceed the available resources. In the context of TESOL TEs, specific job demands include classroom silence, heavy workloads, and conflicting roles, which can result in emotional exhaustion and reduced job satisfaction. Conversely, job resources such as supportive colleagues, professional development opportunities, and institutional recognition can mitigate these pressures and enhance well-being (Granziera, 2022; Sanders et al., 2024). Table 1 outlines key theoretical concepts from the JD-R model and their relevance to TESOL TEs' experiences with classroom silence in the present study context.

Applying the JD-R model to TESOL ITE contexts reveals how classroom stressors (e.g., classroom silence) interact with available resources to shape TEs' emotional and instructional experiences. Research indicates that an imbalance between high demands and limited resources heightens stress and diminishes job satisfaction, adversely affecting TEs' well-being and professional effectiveness (Skaalvik & Skaalvik, 2018). Additionally, TEs are a unique group of professionals where power dynamics—such as hierarchical relationships with administrators, institutional expectations, and the influence they could hold over PTs—play a significant role in their professional experiences and stress levels. These power dynamics can intensify the effects of job demands and influence the availability and effectiveness of resources. Therefore, this study utilizes the JD-R model to explore these dynamics within TESOL ITE programs, specifically examining how job demands such as classroom silence and available resources influence TEs' well-being.

Table 1
JD-R in TESOL TEs' experiences with classroom silence.

Theoretical concept	Definition in the present study context	Examples in TESOL ITE	JD-R's connection to study
Job demands	Aspects of the profession requiring sustained effort and associated with physiological or psychological costs	- Classroom silence: PTs' silence leading to frustration and emotional exhaustion - Heavy workload - Emotional exhaustion from PT disengagement	Examines how these demands impact TESOL TEs' well-being and effectiveness
Job resources	Aspects of the profession that help achieve work goals, reduce job demands, and stimulate personal/professional growth	- Support from colleagues - Professional development opportunities - Institutional recognition	Explores how access to resources buffers the negative effects of job demands on TEs' well-being
Teacher educator well-being	The overall state of emotional, mental, and physical health in relation to professional work	- Stress levels - Emotional resilience - Job satisfaction	Analyzes how the balance of job demands and resources influences TEs' well-being
Impact of classroom silence	The specific influence of learner silence on TEs' emotional and instructional experiences	- Frustration - Decreased engagement - Questioning of teaching effectiveness	Focuses on the emotional toll and instructional outcomes of classroom silence

3. Methodology

3.1. Research design

This study aims to explore the dynamics of classroom silence in TESOL ITE programs from TEs' perspectives, focusing on perceived sources, associated emotions, and instructional outcomes. Using an interpretive qualitative paradigm, it employs an exploratory case study approach (Yin, 2018) to investigate context-specific issues through in-depth data collection. This method is ideal for examining under-researched phenomena, enabling a thorough exploration of TEs' lived experiences and the meanings they attach to classroom silence and its impact on their professional well-being.

This design is well-suited for a focused inquiry into TEs' experiences, allowing for an in-depth analysis of their professional challenges and reflections. By concentrating on a bounded system, the case study uncovers how TEs' professional lives intersect with contextual factors that contribute to classroom silence (White & Cooper, 2022). Furthermore, this study is exploratory in nature, addressing a relatively underexplored area in TESOL teacher education—the role of classroom silence as a workplace challenge that impacts TEs' emotional experiences and instructional practices. Multiple data collection methods were employed, including individual interviews, a paired-depth interview, and weekly voice memos. These tools provided a comprehensive understanding of TEs' perceptions of classroom silence, the emotions they associate with it, and the instructional outcomes they observe in TESOL ITE classrooms.

3.2. Context and participants

This study is situated within a TESOL ITE program in the Faculty of Education in Türkiye. In Türkiye, the Council for Higher Education (CoHE) oversees ITE programs, which have evolved to meet global educational standards. Similar to ITE programs in OECD countries, Türkiye's ITE programs aim to develop skilled educators through a comprehensive four-year curriculum (Eren, 2017; OECD, 2018). The present TESOL ITE program offers subject-specific and pedagogical courses (e.g., TESOL Methodology and Coursebook Evaluation in TESOL; CoHE, 2018) designed to equip TESOL PTs with essential skills for modern language classrooms. The program aligns with global initiatives to enhance instructional quality and teacher preparation, ensuring PTs are well-prepared for the complexities of language teaching.

In the program, Ayşe and Bahar, both experienced TESOL TEs, were recruited for this study due to their extensive experience and active roles in the TESOL ITE program. Their voluntary participation was crucial, as only Ayşe and Bahar, out of four invited TEs of the ITE program, agreed to participate, reflecting their recognition of the value of professional reflection despite their demanding schedules. Ayşe taught courses on integrating language skills into field-experience classes, a vital component of the ITE curriculum aimed at bridging theoretical knowledge with classroom practice, which required high levels of PT participation to develop practical teaching skills.

On the other hand, Bahar taught courses on literature and integrating literature into language teaching, focusing on integrating pedagogical content knowledge into language instruction. These courses also required significant PT engagement, helping them develop skills in using literature for language teaching. Both TEs managed heavy workloads, teaching 12–18 h per week while handling administrative and mentoring responsibilities. The courses they offer, central to PTs' professional growth, relied on active participation to build teaching competencies.

3.3. Data collection

Data for this study were collected following Institutional Review Board (IRB) approval, and consent forms were completed by all participants. Data collection procedures covered individual interviews (Int), a paired-depth interview (PairInt), and weekly voice memos (Vm, W), offering a comprehensive view of the participants' experiences. Researcher notes guided the data collection and analysis procedures. Individual interviews, conducted at the beginning of the 2023–2024 spring term, focused on participants' perspectives on key themes. Each participant received the interview protocol in advance (see Supplementary A) to encourage reflective responses (Haukås & Tishakov, 2024). These interviews, featuring open-ended questions and probing, lasted 45–60 min and were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim for accuracy.

In addition to the individual interviews, a paired depth interview was conducted toward the end of the spring term to explore the collaborative dynamics between the two TESOL TEs within the same ITE program. This joint interview allowed for observing their interactions and provided opportunities for immediate clarification of any discrepancies in their narratives (Wilson et al., 2016). The paired interview underscored the collaborative nature of their roles and offered valuable insights into their shared experiences.

Participants also submitted weekly voice memos after each class to capture ongoing reflections. These memos were recorded via WhatsApp and provided real-time insights into their teaching experiences, particularly regarding PTs' classroom silence and its emotional and pedagogical impacts (see Supplementary B for prompts). Voice memos were efficient and flexible, accommodating TEs' busy schedules and capturing their immediate thoughts and feelings (Heckathorn & Sharpe, 2023), making them more convenient than written journals for this group of professionals. Additionally, the researcher maintained detailed memos throughout data collection, reflecting on participants' experiences with classroom silence, emotional responses, and instructional practices.

3.4. Data analysis

The analysis followed a thematic approach grounded in an inductive, data-driven methodology, capturing explicit and underlying meanings (Boyatzis, 1998; Braun & Clarke, 2006). The initial step involved coding the interviews and voice memo transcriptions, with codes generated directly from the data. Transcriptions and preliminary coding were done using a word processor, while Excel was used to organize, categorize, and cross-check the data against the original recordings for consistency and accuracy (MacLean et al., 2004). This method ensured the analysis aligned closely with participants' authentic voices and experiences. After coding, the data were clustered into themes (see Supplementary C for a sample). Themes emerged through an iterative revision, comparison, and refinement process to identify overlaps and convergence (Cohen et al., 2018; Tracy, 2018). The researcher's notes and reflections informed the thematic categorization, ensuring coherence. Themes were adjusted until saturation was reached, capturing all relevant aspects of participants' experiences. In the multilingual TESOL context, data were collected in Turkish, the participants' native language, which facilitated rapport, comprehension, and a deeper investigation of their experiences, preserving the authenticity and capturing the nuances of their emotional and instructional experiences (Duff, 2022).

3.5. Researcher positionality

The researcher's decade-long collegial relationship with the participants enhanced data quality and depth. As an insider within the department, the researcher possessed essential contextual knowledge of the TEs' experiences. This professional closeness allowed for capturing nuanced reflections on PTs' silence and the TEs' emotional and instructional reactions. The shared history facilitated informal follow-up discussions, providing additional insights into the study's themes. Leveraging this rapport, the researcher conducted interviews and collected weekly voice memos, thereby improving data accuracy and trustworthiness.

The researcher's reflective, immersive role and constant interactions with participants strengthened the study's credibility and validity. Triangulation validated emerging themes by cross-referencing interview data, voice memos, and notes. Informal follow-up conversations provided clarification, particularly on emotional displays. To further ensure trustworthiness, member checking in interviews allowed participants to review preliminary findings and offer feedback, refining the final themes to accurately reflect their experiences.

4. Findings

4.1. Perceived sources of silence in TESOL teacher education (RQ1)

Understanding the sources of silence in TESOL ITE classrooms from the TEs' perspective is crucial for enhancing the initial professional learning experience. Data analysis revealed that TESOL PTs' silence arises from curriculum-related, PT-, and TE-related factors. Addressing these elements allows TEs to develop strategies to encourage participation and reduce silence. Ayşe and Bahar's reflections underscored the importance of addressing all three dimensions.

4.1.1. Curriculum-related sources of silence

The findings revealed that curriculum-related factors significantly contributed to PTs' silence, primarily due to misalignment between course design and PTs' language proficiency. The course content, emphasizing theoretical discussions, intensified silence as PTs faced challenges with intellectual preparedness, low target language proficiency, and limited interaction opportunities. To illustrate these findings, TEs provided insights into how these curriculum-related factors affected classroom dynamics. Ayşe reflected on the high expectations set by the curriculum, stating that "the course content doesn't always align with PTs' proficiency or intellectual levels, leading to more silence" (Int). Bahar further explained that the lack of preparedness and inadequate language skills contributed to PTs' silence: "Sometimes I think it stems from PTs' inadequate preparation prior to discussions, inability to relate the topic to real-life experiences due to limited prior knowledge, and difficulty in articulating ideas in the target language during class discussions" (Int). To address these challenges, Bahar emphasized the use of visual aids to mitigate unfamiliar vocabulary (Vm, W1) and commented that "the course content is too content-heavy, leaving little room for interaction" (Int). She also highlighted that complex topics like "third-generation hybrid cultures" created barriers to comprehension and participation (Vm, W4).

As a result, curriculum-related sources of silence emerged as a critical theme, revealing that misalignment between course demands and PTs' language proficiency and preparedness often reduced participation. TEs both noted that high expectations, content-heavy sessions, and complex materials contributed to PTs' silence, as they struggled with challenging topics and expressing ideas in the target language. In relation, focusing on theoretical content and limited interaction opportunities increased anxiety and lowered participation.

4.1.2. Pre-service teacher-related sources of silence

Data analysis revealed that PTs' professional preparedness, language proficiency, and cultural backgrounds considerably impacted classroom dynamics, frequently resulting in classroom silence due to insufficient language skills, unpreparedness for discussions, and cultural norms discouraging participation. Ayşe indicated, "The silence often arises from students' unpreparedness and inadequate language proficiency. They are not ready for academic discussions and hence choose to stay silent" (PairInt). Bahar agreed, emphasizing that "Some students come from backgrounds where active class participation is not common. This cultural aspect also contributes to the silence" (PairInt). Ayşe further elaborated on the language-related challenges, adding, "Students' language proficiency

is a major factor. They struggle with expressing their thoughts in English, leading them to remain silent during discussions" (Int).

Bahar noted that anxiety about speaking English and unfamiliarity with academic genres contributed to silence: "Unfamiliarity with genres and lack of preparation are significant factors. Students may need more time to organize their thoughts or may avoid participation if unprepared" (VM, W1; W2). Ayşe noted that fear of errors often intensified silence: "Even capable students often remain quiet due to anxiety" (VM, W3). Both TEs recognized the influence of cultural backgrounds and agreed that PT-related factors contributed to the prevalence of classroom silence; as Bahar remarked, "Cultural backgrounds play a significant role. Some students come from cultures where silence is valued" (Int). In conclusion, the analysis indicated that TEs attributed PTs' classroom silence to factors such as limited language proficiency, insufficient preparation, and cultural norms that discourage active participation.

4.1.3. Teacher-educator-related sources of silence

Data analysis indicated that teacher-educator-related factors, including teaching styles, classroom management, and expectations, played a significant role in classroom silence in TESOL courses. Ayşe and Bahar recognized that their teaching styles, particularly allowing time for reflection, occasionally resulted in unintended silence. Ayşe shared how her preference for reflection affected the process: "My teaching style includes giving students ample time to reflect, but sometimes this leads to extended periods of silence, which can be counterproductive" (PairInt). Similarly, Bahar pointed out, "Classroom management strategies need to be adapted to encourage more participation and reduce silence. Setting clear expectations for engagement can help" (Int). Both TEs recognized that unrealistic expectations, especially about PTs' language proficiency and their willingness to communicate, often intensified classroom silence.

Ayşe further stressed the importance of adapting teaching methods to engage quieter PTs, using varied questioning and humor to stimulate interaction (Int; Vm, W1; W2). Despite these efforts, some PTs remained disengaged, underscoring the challenge of finding holistically effective strategies (Vm, W4). Bahar reflected on her approach, admitting, "My teaching style may not be engaging enough for all students", and expressed the persistent challenge: "Managing the classroom and encouraging students [PTs] to speak is a constant challenge in my classes" (Vm, W1). To address this struggle, Bahar employed writing activities and humor to break the silence (Vm, W2; W4). Thus, the findings indicated that addressing silence in TESOL ITE classrooms required aligning curriculum expectations with PTs' language proficiency, improving professional readiness, and refining TEs' instructional decisions.

4.2. TESOL teacher educators' emotional associations with classroom silence and its impact on teaching (RQ2)

Classroom silence in TESOL ITE elicited a range of emotions in TEs, highlighting the complexities of teaching dynamics. Both TEs noted positive, negative, and mixed emotions from managing silence, which led to adjustments in their teaching practices. Such emotions also influenced their approach to classroom engagement.

4.2.1. Positive emotions associated with silence

Data analysis showed that addressing classroom silence gave TESOL TEs a profound sense of satisfaction and achievement. They felt rewarded when PTs were engaged, validating their teaching methods and dedication to interaction. TEs viewed silence as a challenge and a chance for reflection, enhancing their satisfaction when participation ensued. Bahar expressed her gratification: "When they finally engage after a period of silence, it's very rewarding. Seeing them overcome their initial hesitation gives me a sense of accomplishment" (PairInt). Ayşe echoed similar sentiments, noting, "There are moments when a PT who is usually silent speaks up and contributes to the discussion. Those breakthroughs make all the effort worthwhile" (Int). Additionally, Ayşe emphasized the profound satisfaction she gained when she successfully managed to engage the class: "Overcoming the silence is very satisfying ... When I manage the class to engage ... This brings me a profound sense of satisfaction" (Vm, W3).

Ayşe also reflected on the positive aspects of silence, viewing it as a sign of cognitive engagement rather than disengagement in certain situations. She explained, "I think of silence as not always negative; it means they [PTs] are still processing the information" (Int). This understanding led her to focus more on supporting shy students: "I thought maybe I should focus more on the shy ones [PTs], giving them more attention and support" (Vm, W2). She also enjoyed increased participation when discussing personal topics: "When I asked about their cultural traditions, there was more participation. This made me happy because I saw them opening up and engaged" (Vm, W3). Bahar similarly expressed pride in PTs' breakthroughs, feeling validated in her efforts: "I feel immense pride when a usually silent student finally participates" (Int). The findings highlighted the complex relationship between silence and engagement in TESOL ITE classrooms. Both TEs felt professional fulfillment when PTs overcame hesitation and participated, reinforcing their pedagogical commitment. By addressing silence supportively, TEs fostered more inclusive and dynamic environments, encouraging greater PT participation.

4.2.2. Negative emotions associated with silence

Negative emotions like frustration and anxiety were prevalent among the TEs. Bahar stated, "Silence in the classroom increases my stress levels. Sometimes, before class, I ask myself, 'How will it go today?' This uncertainty adds to my anxiety and makes me uneasy about my teaching effectiveness" (Int). Ayşe added, "The persistent silence is frustrating. Despite trying various strategies, their reluctance makes me feel inadequate as a teacher" (Vm, W2). Bahar similarly felt less efficacious when TESOL PTs remained silent despite her efforts: "It makes me question if my materials or methods are effective enough" (Int). Ayşe felt pressured to resolve silence: "During class discussions, I felt passive and realized I was giving the answers myself, which I don't want to do" (Vm, W2). She expressed frustration when TESOL PTs showed a lack of preparation: "I get annoyed when they haven't done the reading because then I have to wait longer for their responses" (Vm, W4). Bahar often felt frustrated due to the frequent silence and lack of response from

students: “The constant silence is frustrating and makes me question my effectiveness ... I keep asking myself how to improve things” (PairInt). She also noted that the absence of interaction during class discussions led to decreased enthusiasm: “The lack of interaction in class discussions leads to my demoralization and a drop in energy ... I feel exhausted afterwards” (Vm, W3).

In her weekly VMs, Bahar reflected on how her classroom management strategies impacted classroom silence: “To encourage engagement, I utilized strategies like incorporating writing tasks and building rapport with students” (Vm, W2). However, she noted that the absence of consequences for unpreparedness significantly contributed to PTs’ reluctance to engage: “When there are no punitive measures for being unprepared, PTs feel less compelled to participate in discussions” (Int). Hence, the reflections highlighted the complex emotions TESOL TEs face with classroom silence. Although they viewed PTs as future professionals, the lack of participation triggered TEs’ negative emotions, including frustration, anxiety, and diminished sense of efficacy.

4.2.3. *Mixed emotions associated with silence*

Data analysis showed that TESOL TEs had mixed emotions about classroom silence, feeling both satisfaction and concern over its impact on student engagement. Both TEs valued silence for reflection but feared it indicated disengagement or lack of preparedness. Their emotions fluctuated between satisfaction with engagement and frustration with the challenges silence presented. Bahar articulated this contradiction, stating, “I value reflective moments that silence brings, but I also worry if students are engaged or disinterested. It’s a mix of satisfaction and concern” (PairInt). Ayşe echoed, “Sometimes, silence allows deep thinking and reflection, which is positive. However, it can also indicate disengagement and lack of preparedness, which is troubling” (PairInt).

Ayşe also acknowledged the difficulty of balancing patience with the desire for more active participation: “I try to be patient because they are processing, but I also want more participation in discussions” (Vm, W2). She added that she felt some responsibility for the PTs’ silence, noting, “I felt somewhat responsible, thinking I should have done more for shy students while focusing more on those unprepared for class” (Vm, W4). Bahar also expressed the duality of her emotions: “There are times when I feel both happy and frustrated due to my students’ engagement in discussions” (Int). TEs were pleased with occasional PT participation breakthroughs but frustrated by how silence disrupted lesson flow. The participants expressed nuanced attitudes toward classroom silence, recognizing it as context-dependent—sometimes conducive to reflection and, in other cases, indicative of disengagement or inadequate preparation—thereby shaping TEs’ experiences, challenges, and pedagogical strategies.

4.3. *Observed outcomes of classroom silence on classroom dynamics, interaction, and engagement in TESOL teacher education (RQ3)*

Both TEs underscored the significance of classroom dynamics in shaping TESOL PTs’ teaching and learning experiences. In particular, their reflections on silence revealed specific challenges they face as TEs. The participants highlighted how silence affects not only the learning environment and teaching methods but also their personal well-being, emphasizing its broader impact on the overall ITE program.

4.3.1. *Learning environment*

Data analysis showed that silence significantly impacted the learning environment, disrupting classroom dynamics, engagement, and effectiveness. It hindered PT-TE and peer interactions, reducing communication and changing the classroom atmosphere. This led to decreased PT participation and fewer contributions, highlighting its broader implications for the TESOL ITE program.

4.3.1.1. *Challenges to classroom dynamics.* Data analysis showed that PT-TE interaction significantly influenced classroom dynamics as the findings underscored the negative impact of silence, which led to PT isolation and hindered effective communication. Bahar noted,

Silence affects how PTs interact with each other ... even a student willing to participate could be influenced by others who are reluctant ... When the classroom is silent, it changes the dynamic completely. Students [PTs] seem more isolated and less willing to collaborate. (PairInt)

This isolating nature of silence impacted the relationships between PTs and TEs, as well as peer interactions, making it harder to foster effective communication and teamwork. Ayşe echoed this sentiment, adding, “Silence disrupts the lesson flow and affects overall classroom dynamics ... this disruption often led some PTs to further disengage, and some remained silent throughout the class, while others start engaging after a while” (Vm, W2).

Further data revealed the differences in classroom dynamics. Ayşe remarked that her 8:30 class was noisy and hard to manage, while her 10:30 class was quieter, attributing these differences to group dynamics (Vm, W3). Cultural factors also influenced engagement, as some PTs viewed the TE as an authority figure: “They see me more as an authority figure, which impacts their engagement ... sometimes due to respecting authority without significant engagement” (Bahar, Vm, W4). Silence also appeared to spread among PTs, as Bahar noted, “... silence was contagious this week; when one group decided to remain silent, others followed” (Vm, W1). This contagious silence hindered peer interactions as Bahar indicated, “... silence affects PT interactions in discussions ... even willing students could be influenced by others’ reluctance to participate” (Int). The data showed that silence affected classroom dynamics, disrupting communication, peer interactions, and collaboration. Its isolating effect and cultural and group dynamics reduced active participation and collaborative learning.

4.3.1.2. *Challenges to PT engagement.* Data analysis revealed that classroom silence significantly impeded PTs’ discussion engagement, highlighting the challenge of maintaining interaction in TESOL ITE contexts. Despite providing discussion questions in advance, Ayşe

noted, “I shared the discussion questions before the class, but PT engagement still remained low. Their silence indicated that they aren’t engaging with the material as I expected” (PairInt). Bahar further asserted: “Engagement drops significantly when students are silent. It’s challenging to maintain an interactive classroom atmosphere under these conditions” (PairInt). In response to these challenges, Ayşe referred to new strategies to promote engagement: “I’ve started using more dynamic and varied materials, such as videos, visuals, and multimodal tools, to keep their attention and encourage participation” (Int). She also adjusted her questioning techniques by using probing and Socratic questioning and relating the content to PTs’ real-life experiences (Vm, W1). Additionally, Ayşe reflected on how rephrasing questions helped improve comprehension: “I explained terms like ‘informal attire’ and gave relatable examples to aid comprehension” (Vm, W2).

Other strategies Ayşe employed included rearranging seating to encourage quieter PTs to participate by placing them at the front during group discussions (Vm, W3). She also used culturally relevant questions to engage quieter students: “Asking culturally relevant questions [about PTs’ real-life] proved effective in engaging quieter students [Pys]” (Vm, W4). Meanwhile, Bahar emphasized that low participation often signaled deeper issues: “PTs’ participation decreases significantly when there is silence, and when a group of students decide to be silent ... even if I bring the most engaging activity ... it seems it is impossible to make them participate” (Int). The findings showed that silence significantly impacted PT discussion engagement, limiting interaction. Both TEs addressed using dynamic teaching methods, relatable content, and cultural awareness to reduce silence and boost participation. These strategies emphasized the importance of adaptability and culturally responsive pedagogy in overcoming classroom silence in the TESOL ITE program.

4.3.1.3. Challenges to professional learning. Data analysis revealed that TEs highlighted the role of the effectiveness of learning outcomes that diminished in a silent classroom. Ayşe affirmed, “Silence leads to less effective learning outcomes because students [PTs] are not actively participating in discussions” (PairInt). Silent PTs were less likely to voice misunderstandings or ask questions, further impacting their learning. Bahar supported this view: “It’s harder to gauge understanding and provide timely feedback when students are silent” (PairInt).

Ayşe highlighted the additional stress of preparing materials to mitigate silence: “I planned tasks before class to make discussions more engaging and assigned tasks on online platforms to ensure they [PTs] read the text beforehand” (Vm, W2). Bahar’s proactive strategy to improve engagement also elevated her preparation time and effort, noting that silence frequently signifies inherent difficulties, as PTs hesitate to articulate their struggles: “Silence could indicate PTs are struggling with the material and are not intellectually prepared for an academic discussion” (Int). These insights demonstrated how classroom silence can hinder interaction and learning outcomes in the TESOL ITE context. In response, TESOL TEs enhanced PTs’ professional learning by preparing engaging materials and creating a supportive environment to address disengagement, which required additional challenges in planning.

4.3.2. Teaching approaches

The subtheme of teaching approaches, derived from analyzing silence’s outcomes, included adaptation strategies and reflective practices. The adaptation involved modifying teaching methods and leveraging silence as an educational tool for classroom management. Reflective practices emphasized self-assessment and instructional adjustments, showing how silence prompted TEs to reevaluate and enhance their teaching. These findings provide insights into silence’s impact on teaching approaches and its significance in the TESOL ITE program.

4.3.2.1. Adaptation strategies. Both TEs adapted their teaching methods to address classroom silence. Bahar used interactive activities and discussion questions, while Ayşe explored the causes of silence, employing it deliberately to encourage reflection but minimizing unproductive silence through dynamic materials. “I’ve started to use more dynamic and varied materials to maintain attention and encourage participation, integrating more videos, visuals, and multimodal tools” (Ayşe, Int). Bahar also adopted diverse questioning techniques and made content more relatable to PTs’ real-life experiences: “I introduce class discussions by sharing content beforehand and relate it to PTs’ real-life experiences to shorten classroom silence” (Bahar, Vm, W1). Both TEs recognized the importance of reflection in refining their teaching approaches. As Bahar noted: “Paying attention to silence made me more reflective about my teaching” (Vm, W3). Thus, the adjustments to teaching strategies and reflective practices were crucial for managing classroom silence and enhancing PT engagement.

4.3.2.2. Reflective practices. The analysis revealed that Bahar adjusted her teaching methods to manage the persistent silence in her classroom better: “When I realized that there is not much I can do when students [PTs] are not willing to participate, I’ve started using silence as a tool to encourage deeper thinking and use deep reflection questions” (Int). This shift in approach allowed her to transform silence from a barrier into an opportunity for promoting critical thinking. Additionally, she incorporated more interactive elements into her lessons, as she explained,

I always try to include interactive activities and thought-provoking discussion questions in my lessons. These strategies are designed to encourage PTs to actively participate and share their ideas, which helps to break the silence and make the learning environment more dynamic and inclusive. (Vm, W3)

This adaptation highlighted the emphasis on fostering a participatory and reflective learning environment. Bahar’s approach underscored the significance of adaptability and reflective practice in TESOL ITE from TEs’ perspective. By strategically using silence to promote deeper thinking and encourage active participation, she continuously refined her instructional methods to better cater to her PTs’ needs, thereby cultivating a more inclusive and dynamic classroom atmosphere.

4.3.3. Personal well-being

The analysis of silence revealed two key subthemes related to TEs' well-being: stress and coping mechanisms, as well as professional satisfaction. The first subtheme emphasized how classroom silence contributes to stress and the various coping strategies TEs employ to manage it, ultimately affecting their professional lives. The second subtheme highlighted how silence impacts job satisfaction, professional identity, and overall fulfillment. These insights clarified the broader effects of classroom silence on TEs' well-being and provided essential implications for the TESOL ITE program.

4.3.3.1. Stress and coping mechanisms. The analysis revealed that managing classroom silence significantly impacted TESOL TEs' well-being in terms of stress and coping mechanisms. For instance, Bahar expressed the emotional tension: "Silence in the classroom increases my stress levels" (PairInt). This reflected a broader need for coping strategies, such as taking breaks and sharing concerns with colleagues to mitigate emotional tensions (Vm, W2). Similarly, Ayşe described experiencing stress due to quiet classrooms: "It's exhausting to keep motivating silent students, but I try to remain patient and understanding ... to do so I take deep breaths to regulate my stress" (Int), demonstrating the emotional labor required to maintain PT engagement. TEs' reflections underscored the significant emotional labor required to engage disengaged or shy PTs who are reluctant to participate in class discussions. Ayşe also emphasized the extra pressure this imposes: "I realized I needed to find a way to deal with both the uninterested and the shy PTs, and that added to my stress" (Vm, W4). Their experiences suggest that the emotional demands of managing classroom silence extend beyond simple frustration, affecting their professional satisfaction and, in turn, overall professional well-being. In addition to stress management and regulation strategies, both TEs emphasized the importance of professional support.

4.3.3.2. Professional satisfaction. The analysis revealed that classroom silence was a major source of stress for TESOL TEs. Bahar highlighted this stress, stating,

Classroom silence significantly elevates my stress levels. Before class, I often wonder, 'How will it go today? Will the students engage, or will it be another silent session?' These uncertainties increase my anxiety and make me more apprehensive about my teaching effectiveness. (Int)

Bahar also acknowledged that silence impacted her job satisfaction: "Silence in the classroom directly impacts my overall job satisfaction. Sometimes I question my role and the effectiveness of my teaching methods" (PairInt). She reflected on how silence influenced her sense of her professional identity, saying, "The lack of PT engagement influences my sense of self as it makes me question if I am truly making a difference in the program" (PairInt). Additionally, the stress from managing silence affected her personal life, as she noted, "Balancing work and personal life becomes harder when classroom silence persists because I keep questioning that class experience even after the class" (Vm, W4). This persistent stress and emotional labor underscore the profound impact of silence on TEs' well-being, job satisfaction, and sense of professional identity. These findings reveal the need for structured support networks and professional development to help TESOL TEs navigate the emotional complexities associated with managing classroom stressors.

5. Discussion

In response to the growing interest in emotion-regulation strategies among language teachers facing classroom stressors (e.g., [Thumvichit, 2023](#)) and English language teachers' beliefs about learner engagement (e.g., [Acosta-Manzano & Mercer, 2024](#)), this study explored TESOL TEs' experiences in the ITE program in Türkiye. Specifically, it examined how classroom silence interacted with TEs' emotional responses and instructional practices, providing insights into the challenges and strategies TEs use to foster PT engagement.

The complexity of managing silence (e.g., [Zeng, 2020](#)) was evident in its connection to emotional labor, curriculum misalignment, and cultural expectations. TEs' emotional responses to silence were key in shaping their professional satisfaction and engagement. These dynamics influenced how TEs addressed the challenges of classroom silence, particularly concerning curriculum demands and cultural barriers. The following sections explore the impact of silence on TEs' emotional experiences and instructional practices, focusing on the balance between its negative and positive aspects, the role of cultural background, and strategies for fostering a supportive professional learning environment.

5.1. Challenges of classroom silence for TESOL TEs

The findings of this study confirm that addressing classroom silence is crucial for TESOL TEs in ITE programs. Consistent with previous research in educational settings (e.g., [Smith & King, 2018](#); [Thumvichit, 2023](#)), silence often stemmed from PTs' professional readiness, language proficiency, and cultural backgrounds. [Smith and King \(2018\)](#) emphasize students' lack of confidence in their language abilities frequently leads to reduced participation, reflecting deeper issues in TESOL contexts, which particularly addresses the job demands TEs face when managing complex classroom dynamics ([Demerouti et al., 2001](#)).

This study supports [Acosta-Manzano and Mercer's \(2024\)](#) claim that aligning tasks with PTs' proficiency levels while keeping them challenging can help mitigate the barriers posed by silence. As they suggest, even minimal interaction can reduce the burden of silence since "any engagement is likely to be better than no engagement" (p. 15). Similarly, [Bao \(2023\)](#) notes that curriculum misalignment—when course content doesn't match students' language proficiency—can intensify silence, frustrating both PTs and TEs in

the TESOL ITE context.

Beyond surface-level disengagement, this study reveals that classroom silence reflects deeper emotional and instructional challenges for TEs. Jaworski et al. (2012) and Nakane (2007) show that silence can hold different meanings for the stakeholders depending on context. PTs may view silence as neutral or respectful, especially in specific cultural contexts (e.g., King & King, 2013; Nakane, 2007, 2012), while TEs often interpret it as apathy or resistance in the course context, leading to frustration and self-doubt. These findings align with Shachter's (2023) observation that teachers/TEs frequently experience discomfort when faced with silence, perceiving it as a failure of engagement or a reflection of their instructional shortcomings.

Curriculum adaptation and reforms can heighten these emotional responses, making silence even more emotionally laborious for educators (e.g., Cross & Hong, 2009). Bao (2023) argues that heavy theoretical content and high curriculum demands can intensify silence as students struggle with preparedness and language proficiency, mirroring the experiences of TEs in this study. However, it is essential to acknowledge the positive aspects of silence in teacher education. Silence can facilitate deeper cognitive processing, allowing PTs time to reflect and internalize information, ultimately enhancing learning (e.g., Bao & Nguyen, 2020; King & Harumi, 2020). Nakane (2012) suggests that in some cultures, silence is a valued part of the learning process, encouraging students to contemplate before engaging. This duality indicates that classroom silence is not just a sign of disengagement but can be an integral part of learning, which can evoke mixed emotions in practice.

Understanding the balance between silence's negative and positive aspects enables TEs to develop strategies that harness its benefits while addressing its challenges. For instance, implementing wait time after posing questions can promote critical thinking (e.g., Novitaningrum et al., 2020). On the other hand, some studies challenge the optimistic view of silence, as Bao (2023) argues that prolonged silence may hinder language practice by limiting opportunities for verbal interaction and feedback. Bao and Nguyen (2020) also suggest that excessive silence can impede language development, suggesting that silence is not inherently beneficial, especially in professional learning contexts. In a professional learning context (e.g., TESOL ITE), thus, these perspectives underscore the importance of TEs carefully balancing silent periods with active engagement, ensuring that silence fosters reflective learning/teaching without undermining opportunities for practical target language development and professional growth.

5.2. Cultural influences on classroom silence

Cultural background significantly shapes how both TEs and PTs experience and interpret silence in the classroom. In many East Asian cultures, silence is associated with respect and attentiveness, leading PTs from these backgrounds to participate less verbally (e.g., Nakane, 2007; King & King, 2013). Nakane's (2007) study on Japanese students in Australian universities highlights how cultural norms influence silent behavior, often leading to misunderstandings in cross-cultural educational settings. TEs from Western backgrounds may misinterpret this silence as disengagement, resulting in misunderstandings and increased stress. This can also apply to cultural differences among stakeholders from the same country but with diverse socio-economic backgrounds (e.g., King & King, 2013), leading to similar challenges in communication and interpretation. However, attributing silence solely to cultural norms can be overly simplistic and risks perpetuating stereotypes (Pierce & Gilles, 2022). Nakane (2012) emphasizes that individual personality traits, language proficiency, and situational factors also play significant roles in silent behavior in the classroom. King and Harumi (2020) additionally report that students exhibit varying degrees of silence even within the same cultural group based on personal comfort and confidence levels. Therefore, interpreting silence could display a context-dependent nature and would be challenging to categorize and label.

The present findings suggest that while cultural background shapes classroom dynamics, it is not the sole factor influencing TEs' experiences. Institutional policies, individual differences, and situational contexts also significantly affect TEs' emotional responses and instructional practices. Singh and Doherty (2004) warn against overemphasizing cultural differences, advocating for intercultural dialogue rather than attributing challenges solely to culture. Developing cultural competence and adopting a nuanced understanding of silence allows TEs to recognize its multifaceted nature and adapt their instructional strategies. Incorporating culturally responsive teaching practices (e.g., Gay, 2018) can bridge communication gaps and create a more inclusive learning environment. Recognizing that silence can indicate respect, contemplation, or cognitive processing in the ITE context helps TEs better address PTs' needs (Hanna, 2023).

5.3. TESOL TEs' emotional responses and instructional practices

In this study, TEs' emotional responses to classroom silence were critical; silence often triggered discomfort, frustration, or resistance, especially when perceived as PT disengagement (e.g., Reda, 2009). These reactions align with broader findings that classroom dynamics significantly shape teacher emotions and well-being (e.g., Burić & Frenzel, 2023; Thumvichit, 2024). Similar to the findings of Smith and King (2018), who report that teachers often feel increased stress and reduced job satisfaction when faced with persistent classroom silence, TEs in this study experienced emotional labor associated with managing silence in class discussions.

Through the lens of the Job Demands-Resources (JD-R) model, the study reveals a critical imbalance between job demands and resources in the TESOL ITE context. High job demands—such as classroom silence, lack of participation, and disengagement from PTs—paired with limited resources, such as consistent feedback and social support, confirm findings from Maslach and Leiter (2016), suggesting these factors contribute to significant stress and the potential for “silent burnout”. Bao (2023) also highlights how the lack of institutional support increases the emotional labor of educators while working in unresponsive classrooms. This aligns with existing literature on teacher stress and burnout, consistently identifying classroom management as a critical stressor (Kyriacou, 2001; Wettstein et al., 2021). Additionally, examining the emotional aspects of teaching and the influence of significant others on teachers'

well-being highlights the need to address these stressors (Nazari et al., 2024) and the diversity in exploring emotions within the context of language education (De Costa & Nazari, 2024). This perspective aligns with the growing body of literature on emotional labor in teaching (Benesch, 2017; De Costa & Nazari, 2024; Gkonou & Miller, 2023), which highlights the emotional demands placed on TEs and the potential consequences on their psychological well-being in teacher education.

Significantly, this study stands out by uncovering classroom silence as a hidden and often overlooked stressor in TESOL ITE programs, providing a unique contextual framework for applying the JD-R model to TESOL teacher education. By addressing this specific challenge, the study enhances the understanding of potential stressors in ITE settings, offering critical insights into how silence impacts both emotional well-being and instructional effectiveness in TESOL ITE contexts. Similarly, Nakane's (2007) work underscores the importance of understanding silence not just as a student behavior but as a factor significantly affecting teacher/TE well-being and instructional practices.

Furthermore, the findings highlight the critical role of emotional regulation strategies among TEs in managing the stress associated with classroom silence. Gross and John (2003) differentiate between response-focused emotional regulation (i.e., suppression) and antecedent-focused regulation (i.e., reappraisal). TEs who resort to suppression may attempt to hide their frustration, which can lead to increased stress and reduced well-being. In contrast, those who engage in reappraisal actively could reinterpret the meaning of classroom silence, potentially viewing it as an opportunity for PT reflection or cultural expression. This approach aligns with the need to implement reflective practices and relevant support mechanisms to promote reappraisal, thereby enhancing emotional awareness and reducing negative emotional responses.

Although exploratory, this study raises crucial questions for further research, confirming that TESOL TEs' beliefs strongly influence their teaching practices, similar to studies on teacher beliefs (e.g., Gallagher & Scrivner, 2024). It builds on earlier research by highlighting the need for TESOL program administrators and curriculum developers to understand how classroom dynamics, especially silence, affect PT engagement and target language use in TESOL contexts.

The findings significantly contribute to the existing literature by identifying TEs' understanding of the internal factors (e.g., self-related challenges, anxiety; e.g., Soo & Goh, 2017) and external factors (e.g., content-related difficulties; e.g., Nguyen et al., 2023) contributing to classroom silence and hindering PT engagement in TESOL ITE programs. These insights confirm an understanding of how these factors amplify stress and call for practical implications for enhancing professional engagement and well-being among TESOL stakeholders (e.g., Sak & Gürbüz, 2024). Previous research has highlighted the role of self-efficacy and student-teacher relationships in shaping classroom participation (e.g., Herman et al., 2018), reinforcing that exploring both internal emotional states and external classroom dynamics is crucial.

By addressing these factors through targeted interventions, such as tailored professional development programs, TESOL ITE programs can foster a more inclusive, interactive, and self-paced professional learning and sharing environment (e.g., Nolan & Molla, 2019). Additionally, the findings corroborate the suggestions of Cochran-Smith et al. (2020), highlighting the importance of TEs and key stakeholders adopting a comprehensive strategy to support TEs.

Further, the findings emphasize McCarthy's (2021) observations that combining emotional intelligence with responsive pedagogical approaches is crucial for addressing the stress factors and lack of engagement that impede participation in educational settings.

Finally, the study confirms Fives and Buehl's (2012) suggestions on the complex relationship between teachers' perceptions of student behavior regarding disengagement and teachers' beliefs about effective learning. When PT behaviors deviate from these expectations, the findings align with earlier research by showing that such deviations are often misinterpreted as disengagement rather than alternative forms of participation (e.g., cultural norms of silence; Nakane, 2007). This misalignment echoes the work of Singh and Gautam (2024), where mismatches between teacher expectations and student behavior were shown to heighten stress levels, ultimately compromising teaching effectiveness and job satisfaction. By doing so, the study aligns closely with previous findings that emphasize the critical role of teacher engagement in improving student performance, further demonstrating the need to address emotional responses and instructional dynamics in TESOL ITE contexts.

5.4. Limitations of the study

This study provides valuable insights into the relationship between classroom silence and TESOL TEs' emotional and instructional practices. However, a significant limitation of this research is the very small sample size, involving only two TESOL TEs. While the findings provide valuable, in-depth insights into the experiences of the two participating TEs as its strength, it is essential to acknowledge that the small sample size limits the extent to which these results can be transferred to other contexts. The themes identified may not capture the full spectrum of experiences among TESOL TEs in different settings. Therefore, the insights should be considered as context-specific, highlighting areas for further exploration rather than definitive conclusions applicable to all TESOL ITE contexts.

To address this limitation, future research should include a more extensive and diverse sample of TESOL TEs. Increasing the number of participants would enhance the robustness of the findings and allow for greater generalizability. Additionally, incorporating perspectives from different educational settings (e.g., online), and teaching experiences (e.g., novice) would provide a more comprehensive understanding of how classroom silence impacts TEs' well-being and instructional practices across various TESOL ITE contexts.

The reliance on self-reported data introduces potential bias, as participants may interpret their experiences subjectively and may be influenced by social desirability, potentially skewing responses to reflect what they believe is expected or acceptable. This could lead to over-reporting of positive behaviors or under-reporting of challenges, such as negative teacher characteristics that contribute to students'/PTs' unwillingness to communicate in the classes (Raksawong et al., 2024), thereby limiting the study's ability to capture the

complexity of participants' experiences fully. To mitigate social desirability bias, future research could incorporate anonymous surveys, stakeholder observations, or triangulation with objective data sources to provide a more balanced and accurate representation of TESOL TEs' experiences.

Another limitation arises from the nature of the relationship between the researcher and participants. Both participants had been colleagues with the researcher for over 10 years, and given their familiarity with the study context and shared experiences, the collected data were sometimes characterized by limited elaboration. While this facilitated efficient communication, it may have constrained the depth of the data. Additionally, micro-political and power-related dynamics inherent in the professional context could have influenced the interactions, potentially reducing the openness and thoroughness of responses. Despite precautions (e.g., member checking; see section 3.5), participants may have assumed mutual understanding and, as a result, not fully elaborated on specific points.

In summary, this exploratory study provides valuable insights into TESOL TEs' experiences with classroom silence, but its limited sample size and scope suggest that findings should be interpreted within their specific context. Future research could expand data collection by involving other stakeholders (e.g., PTs) and incorporating observations or self-report scales to better understand classroom engagement and silence in TESOL ITE contexts.

5.5. Implications for further studies

This study offers several key implications for TESOL teacher education. First, TESOL TEs must ensure that curriculum design aligns with PTs' language proficiency and intellectual readiness, making instructional materials accessible and sufficiently challenging. Identifying curriculum-induced silence highlights a significant gap, where the mismatch between course demands and PTs' proficiency levels likely inhibits active participation. High expectations, content-heavy sessions, and complex materials could increase anxiety and reduce engagement, posing challenges for TEs in maintaining interactive professional learning environments. To address this, scaffolding strategies (e.g., self-paced professional development, [Eyerici, 2024](#)) could be incorporated, and multi-modal, culturally relevant materials that promote engagement, participation, and effective learning outcomes could be used ([Donahue-Keegan et al., 2019](#)). Additionally, TESOL ITE programs might consider the secondary implication of integrating an English for Specific Purposes (ESP) course/module explicitly designed for TESOL PTs. Such a course could provide PTs with targeted linguistic and pedagogical skills, aligning their language proficiency with TESOL-specific instructional demands, thus enhancing their confidence and competence in using the field-related content knowledge. By doing so, the ESP course could also reduce ITE classroom silence and foster increased participation in TESOL teacher education programs.

Second, professional development programs are crucial for equipping TESOL TEs with the skills to navigate the emotional challenges of teaching-related stressors. These programs should focus on building emotional awareness and resilience, helping TEs manage stress, and preventing burnout from high job demands. In line with the JD-R model, when demands cannot be reduced, the next best strategy is to increase job resources ([Ruderman et al., 2017](#)). Therefore, organizations and individuals who are unable to reduce work demands should prioritize expanding available resources. Incorporating reflective practices enables TEs to critically assess their responses to silence and refine their instructional approaches. Additionally, collaborative professional sharing activities, such as peer discussions, reflective dialogues, and group problem-solving, can further support TEs' well-being by offering structured opportunities for collective reflection, thus increasing the resources available to help them cope with job demands.

Third, fostering open communication channels in professional development programs and mentoring initiatives tailored for TEs is crucial for reducing micro-power dynamics and promoting collaboration (e.g., [Granziera et al., 2022](#)). These initiatives encourage peer support and the exchange of best practices, helping to mitigate feelings of isolation and strengthen professional growth. By promoting a collaborative approach, professional development creates a supportive environment where TEs can collectively address challenges, enhancing both their emotional resilience and instructional effectiveness ([Greenglass et al., 2020](#)). This shared responsibility for growth ultimately strengthens the TESOL ITE programs (e.g., [Johnson et al., 2004, 2005](#)).

Fourth, enhancing emotional awareness and building resilience among TEs can be achieved by incorporating reflective practices that promote reappraisal (i.e., antecedent-focused emotion regulation, [Gross & John, 2003](#)), allowing TEs to reframe classroom silence. Instead of interpreting silence as disengagement, TEs can view it as student reflection or a culturally influenced communication style, reducing the need for emotional suppression (i.e., response-focused emotion regulation; [Gross & John, 2003](#)). Professional development programs, including self-paced modules tailored for TESOL TEs, should focus on emotional awareness and regulation strategies. By fostering emotional resilience through these targeted programs, TEs can more effectively manage the emotional complexities of their classrooms.

Lastly, adopting culturally responsive teaching practices is essential for TEs to effectively address the cultural norms that shape PT participation. By developing awareness of PTs' diverse cultural backgrounds, TEs can tailor their instructional strategies to be more inclusive and sensitive to communication styles that may value silence as a form of respect or reflection (e.g., [Nakane, 2007, 2012](#)). In turn, cultural competence training equips TEs with the skills to recognize and honor these differences, reducing the misinterpretation of classroom stressors while enhancing PT engagement and enriching the professional learning experience by validating and incorporating diverse perspectives.

Overall, these implications underscore the need for TESOL ITE programs and institutions to adopt a holistic approach. By integrating curriculum alignment, emotional support, open communication, institutional collaboration, and cultural responsiveness, this study provides valuable insights for improving teaching and supporting TEs' well-being, ultimately enhancing PTs' learning outcomes. This comprehensive strategy addresses critical challenges and leverages opportunities to create a more engaging and effective TESOL teaching and learning environment. The study's contribution lies in highlighting these interconnected factors and offering practical

solutions that can be applied at both programmatic and institutional levels.

6. Conclusion

The findings of this study are highly significant for TESOL and TESOL teacher education, offering critical insights into the often-overlooked emotional and cultural dimensions of teaching. Demonstrating how classroom silence impacts TESOL TEs' emotional responses and instructional practices, the study emphasizes the need for teacher education programs to integrate comprehensive support mechanisms focusing on emotional resilience and cultural competence. Equipping TEs with strategies to interpret and manage class stressors, such as silence, can lead to more effective engagement with PTs, thereby enhancing professional learning outcomes.

To further advance the field, future research should build on these findings by exploring diverse professional learning contexts (e.g., online learning environments) where classroom silence dynamics may differ. Including perspectives from other stakeholders (e.g., PTs) will provide a more holistic understanding of the teaching-related stressors. Additionally, examining the long-term effects of interventions designed to manage classroom silence through classroom observations and longitudinal studies will enhance the validity and applicability of the present findings.

In conclusion, this study makes a significant contribution by examining the factors influencing TEs' emotional responses and instructional practices in the TESOL ITE context, emphasizing the importance of addressing emotional labor in teaching, promoting culturally responsive pedagogy, and advocating for systemic institutional changes. These efforts better support TEs in their professional roles, improve professional learning experiences for PTs, and foster more equitable and effective professional learning environments, advancing the field of TESOL teacher education.

Informed consent statement

Informed consent was obtained from all participants involved in the study.

Institutional review board statement

This study was conducted in accordance with established ethical guidelines and was approved by the Institutional Review Board of Bolu Abant İzzet Baysal University (protocol code: 2024/02, approved on March 1, 2024).

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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Declaration of competing interest

The author declares no conflict of interest.

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Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2024.103530>.

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